FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

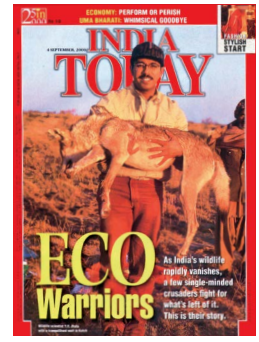
Birds have been around on Planet Earth since the Jurassic days. They are, in fact, the dinosaurs that survived the Great Extinction 65 million years ago, which killed off all their non-winged counterparts. At one of the latest counts of 1,317, India is host to nearly 12 per cent of the world's avian species. But a large number of them are on the decline, some more rapidly than the others. India got its own Red Data Book on these numbers last year in August, with the State of India's Birds (SoIB) report for 2023. Its findings are truly worrying and call for urgent action.

The report found that out of the 942 species that were under assessment, 98 species of birds had declined by as much as 50 per cent in the past three decades. It recommended 14 of these to be added to the Red List of the threatened species maintained by the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN). Three of these species could already be extinct, as they have not been sighted for decades—the Manipur bush quail, the Himalayan quail and the Jerdon's courser. What's worse, the survey shows that another 106 had declined by 25 per cent and could find themselves in the endangered list in the next two decades alone. In all, SoIB 2023 has 178 species that it considers to be of high priority for conservation and another 323 species in the list of those at moderate risk. Together, they constitute 53 per cent of all the species surveyed. Raptors, migratory shorebirds and ducks have declined the most. But things are no better for avian specialists of open ecosystems, rivers and coasts. So, the Malabar grey hornbill, a vast congregation of which inhabits the Valparai plateau in the Western Ghats, declined by 56 per cent between 2004 and 2018—less than a decade and a half.

So, what's the main cause for the alarming fall in numbers of Indian birds? There are many. Climate change looms over everything as a major cause. Even the 0.8° Celsius increase in mean global temperatures in the past 150 years has upset the delicate balance of life for many birds, affecting migratory, nesting and breeding patterns. Migratory birds are now going upward and northward in search of cooler climes. In the summer of 2022, Gujarat saw the strange spectacle of birds falling from the sky because they were dehydrated. Call them martyrs of a much wider 'avocalypse'. Unseasonal rains and artificial irrigation systems have wreaked havoc on the breeding behaviour of the Sarus crane.

The other major reasons are that India's birds are also losing their homes, whether in the marshes and the wetlands, the forest, or even in the open. India's 201,503 wetlands, which harbour an extraordinary number of bird species, are under extreme stress. The SoIB reports a dire 50-80 per cent decline over the long term in those species that thrive on wetlands. Loss of forest cover is another culprit. You may think of Arunachal Pradesh as mostly pristine nature, but that's past. Now, depleting forest cover puts the Wreathed hornbill in mortal danger and in SoIB's list of species on high conservation priority. Plain 'green' does not suffice. Natural forests have immense tree variety, offering food and dwelling resources for a vast number of birds. But commercial monocultures, which began in the colonial period and have exploded since Independence, tend to narrow that down to much fewer species. Oil palm plantations, for instance, which have grown over 30-fold since the 1990s, support only 14 per cent of the bird species that can be seen in the rainforests next to them in Mizoram. Only 50 per cent of the woodpeckers in Uttarakhand's old sal forests can survive in the teak plantations taking over the state. About 25 per cent of bird species are lost in tea plantations that come up next to rainforests.

Bird deaths and decline are also caused by human callousness in India. The Slender-billed vulture is among them. In Delhi, at one time, it was not rare to see hordes of them hulked on treetops on the fringes of city spaces—an air force always at the ready to perform their unwholesome but most necessary duty. But bovine carrion poisoned by livestock drug diclofenac across the country ended that ancient vigil. Vulture population has declined by more than 90 per cent in the country.



September 4, 2000

It is never too early to take, well, a bird's eye view of the crisis. Senior Associate Editor Sonali Acharjee does exactly that in our cover story this week, 'India's Vanishing Birds', drawing a grim picture of India's avianscape from the data thrown up by SoIB 2023, which was put together by 13 major conservation and research organisations based in India. How does all this matter? Well, birds are not just a barometer of ecological health, they are also its guarantors. Seed dispersal and pollination, overall species balance via predation, disease control, the role they play in the web of life is vital. The Wreathed hornbill, in fact, is called the 'farmer of the forest'. The much-reviled vulture is one of the species that can foretell the ecological dangers ahead. As Wildlife SOS CEO and co-founder Kartick Satyanarayan tells us, "If birds can't survive, it won't be long before humans will find it hard to survive too."

Wisdom dictates that we care more than two hoots for the owl. To do that, governments, researchers and ordinary citizens must come together to shape a future in which man and bird can coexist. To save the birds, we must first collate data on them. SoIB 2023 is a worthy initiative in that direction. We could also follow the lessons from the species that have managed to survive, like the Indian peafowl or the Asian koel. Or draw cheer from the fact that the humble house sparrow, which had almost vanished from urban landscapes, is back in our backyards. Community-driven efforts, such as the one to protect the Sarus crane in Madhya Pradesh, or to increase the numbers of the Greater adjutant storks in Bihar, should also prove instructive. "We have a moral obligation to protect birds," says ornithologist V. Santharam. "If not for the fact that we have inherited this planet and must make space for all life, then for how much we enjoy birds—their songs and colours." Indeed, what will life be without birdsong.

(Aroon Purie)